JUNIORS

League age 13 and 14 | 12" ball | 43 ft pitching

The step to middle school and high school softball. Girls pitch from 43 feet and play the full game against teams from across the district.

PURPOSE PROPOSAL

Juniors keeps girls playing softball through middle school and gets them ready for high school softball. BLS had 26 Juniors players on 2 teams last spring, so keeping every girl coming back matters as much as winning.

These girls are the role models for every younger division.

GAME RULES THAT CHANGE COACHING RULE

- Every girl plays at least 6 defensive outs. Continuous batting order.
- Courtesy runner for the pitcher or catcher when there are 2 outs.
- Little League sets no pitching limit in Juniors. The coach manages each pitcher's innings.
- Up to 3 coaches on the field. A team can play with 8, but the 9th spot in the order is an out.
- No new inning after 2 hours 30 minutes. Weekday games start at 6:00 pm.

WHAT LITTLE LEAGUE SAYS LITTLE LEAGUE

- Junior League Softball is for ages 12 to 14.
- 60 ft bases, 43 ft pitching distance, 12 inch ball.
- Games are 7 innings. A game ends early at a 15 run lead after 4 innings or a 10 run lead after 5.
- Little League sets no pitching limit in Juniors. A local league or district may add its own.
- Runners can leave on the release of the pitch, and the dropped third strike is in play.
- Head-first slides, metal cleats and an on-deck batter are all allowed.
- A pitcher who is taken out can come back to pitch later in the game.
- Little League's regular season minimum is 6 defensive outs and 1 at-bat for every player, every game.

FOCUS SKILLS PROPOSAL

1. **Pitcher.** Command of 2 pitches from 43 ft, and pitching to a plan.
2. **Catcher.** Blocking, throwing out runners, and leading the defense.
3. **Team defense.** Every situation: bunts, first-and-third, relays, pickoffs.
4. **Hitting.** Adjusting to faster pitching, hitting behind runners, bunting and slapping.
5. **Playing more than one position.** High school coaches value girls who can play two.

BY THE END OF THE SEASON PROPOSAL

- Every girl can play at least 2 positions.
- Every team has at least 3 girls who can pitch from 43 ft for strikes.
- Every girl knows her job in every common situation.
- Every girl wants to play again next year.

NOT ENOUGH, TOO MUCH PROPOSAL

NOT ENOUGH

- Girls play only one position.
- Practices have no plan, just batting practice.
- Older girls are never asked to lead.

TOO MUCH

- Pitching a girl in league games the same weekend as travel ball without checking her total innings.
- More than 3 team practices a week.
- Coaching every pitch from the dugout during games.

A 90-MINUTE PRACTICE PROPOSAL

Warm up + throw 15	Positions 25	Team defense 30	Live hitting 20

- **Positions:** each girl works a second position.
- **Team defense:** situations at game speed.
- **Live hitting:** against your own pitchers, with a count and runners on base.

COACH'S ROLE PROPOSAL

- Treat the girls like the older players they are. Ask for their input.
- Check in with families about travel ball and school schedules, so no girl is overused.
- Tell parents at the first meeting how playing time and pitching will work.